

**MOROCCO***

Capital city: Rabat
Area: 172,316 sq miles (446,300 sq km)
Population: 30,600,000
Official language: Arabic
Major religions: Muslim 99%, Christian 1%
Government: Monarchy with democratic system
Currency: Moroccan dirham
Adult literacy rate: 51%
Life expectancy: 68 years
People per doctor: 2,000
Televisions: 160 per 1,000 people

* Figures include Western Sahara

MOROCCO

MOROCCO'S WARM CLIMATE, sandy beaches, and stunning mountain scenery make it a popular destination for vacationers. Tourism, along with agriculture and phosphate production, is vital to the country's economy. In 1956, Morocco gained its independence from the French, who had governed it since 1912. It is one of the few Arab countries to be ruled by a king, Mohammed VI. Since coming to the throne in 1999, King Mohammed has won international recognition for his moderate leadership. The main issues facing Morocco today are Islamic fundamentalism and the undecided fate of the Western Sahara region in the south.



Berber wedding ceremony

BERBERS

Since the Arab invasions of the 8th century, the local Berber people have lived in villages high up in the Atlas Mountains. Most Berbers converted to Islam, but kept their own culture and way of life. They call themselves *Imazighen*, or "people of the land." Today, about a third of Moroccans are Berber speaking, although most also speak Arabic and French.



The numerous, carefully planned streets in the old city of Fez look chaotic from a distance.



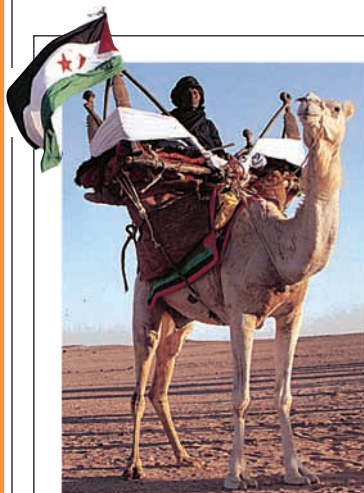
Carpets with symbolic patterns and ornate metalwork lanterns are made by local people.

ARTS AND CRAFTS

Millions of tourists visit Morocco each year to relax on the beaches along the Atlantic coast or to explore the historical cities of Fez and Marrakesh. The cities' colorful *souks*, or markets, are a treasure chest of traditional goods and handicrafts, such as Moroccan leather, silver jewelry, and handwoven carpets.

AN ISLAMIC CITY

The ancient Moroccan city of Fez is a good example of a traditional Islamic town. Each part has been designed with a purpose, as set out in the Koran, the Muslim holy book. The streets are narrow to provide shade, but wide enough to let a pair of fully laden camels pass through. Houses have small, high windows on street walls to guard their owners' privacy. In the city center stands the largest mosque, surrounded by the *souks*, or markets.



A supporter of the Polisario in the Western Sahara

WESTERN SAHARA

This is a desert region south of Morocco with a population of some 200,000 people. It was formerly ruled by Spain. Since 1975, Morocco has been fighting a war for control of the region and its valuable mineral resources. Opposing the Moroccans are the Polisario, a guerilla force of desert tribesmen who want complete independence for the Western Sahara.



A phosphate-processing factory in the south of Morocco

ECONOMY

Morocco's economy depends on three major industries – tourism, agriculture, and phosphates. Farm products make up about a third of exports. The main crops are cereals, vegetables, citrus fruits, and dates. Irrigation systems pipe water to many dry areas for farming. Morocco is the world's third largest producer of phosphates, which are used to make chemicals and fertilizers. Large factories process the phosphates for export.

Find out more

CARPET MAKING: 144, 155, 165
IRRIGATION: 155, 156, 217
ISLAM: 275
MONARCHY: 270–271